

ANNA NAGAR

Purasawalkam » Villivakkam » Kolathur » Nazarathpettai » Pattabiram » Maduravoyal » Koyambedu » Tiruverkadu » Puzhal » Kilpauk » Perambur » Mogappair

Avadi » Ayyappakkam » Tiruninravur » Nerkundram » Moolakadai » Ayanavaram » Retteri » Padi » Ambattur » Tirumullaivoyal » Aminjikarai » Vysarpadi » Red Hills



Gnanambal Garden Second Street in Ayanavaram. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Living room versus loading bay at street in Ayanavaram

A cul-de-sac, Gnanambal Garden Second Street is choked by three warehousing units, transport vehicles heading to them often hogging the narrow street and sometimes keeping residents on 'house arrest'

R. RAGU

Gnanambal Garden Second Street at Vasantha Nagar in Chinna Chembarambakkam within Ayanavaram is not meant to be loud. By its design, it should live slow and be a picture of quiet. But it has edited its intended fate, even attempting what is nigh-impossible: "out-bustling" the nearby Konnur High Road, and strangely, on some days, coming close to pulling it off.

A seventy-metre-long cul-de-sac, with around 50 houses to its name, Gnanambal Second Street is a residential space, but one strangely displaying commercial interests, to the chagrin of its

residents.

On condition of anonymity, a resident of Gnanambal Second Street observes that on the street, three commercial units have their operations, each representing a different trade but united in the fact that they function as something of a warehouse.

The resident elaborates: "A pharmaceutical establishment, a two-wheeler spare parts unit and another unit which stores ingredients that go into making fruit juices for export have vehicles wheeling into the street for loading and unloading purposes. These trucks are often parked in front of the gates, and sometimes they have an overnight stay at the street. In the evening, around 15 medical representatives would park their motorcycles haphazardly on the street, often in front of gates, making movement difficult for residents. As the street is only around 26 feet wide, unauthorised parking is often debilitating."

The resident continues: "In addition, a corporate office on the street adds its share of chaos, again through unauthorised parking. It beats us how such outright commercial activities can be carried out in a residential area. We have drawn the attention of Greater Chennai Corporation and the Chennai City Traffic Police to this anomaly, but no remedial action has been taken."

Higher secondary status sought for GCC school in Ambattur

A residents welfare association is seeking this feature for the benefit of boys studying there. The lack of a government-run higher secondary school in the region is reportedly prompting this demand

L. KANTHIMATHI

United Welfare Associations – Ambattur, a federation of residents associations in Ambattur seeks the Greater Chennai Corporation-run, co-educational Chennai High School on Vasuki Street at Cholapuram in Ambattur be scaled up to include higher secondary education.

United Welfare Associations – Ambattur along with Parents Teachers Association is pursuing this matter with GCC for the past five years.

"We are seeking higher secondary classes exclusively for boys because a girls school with a higher secondary facility exists at Varadharajapuram in Ambattur near OT bus terminus. But there is no government school in Am-



battur offering higher secondary classes for boys," says B.V. Ramadoss, a member of PTA. According to PTA, this school at Valmiki Street was established in the early 1960s as a primary school and was upgraded as a middle school and high school in 2001 and 2011 respectively. "This May, close to 1,000 students passed out of class 10 from the high school in Vasuki Street and around 450 among them were boys. This is a considerable number warranting establishment of a higher secondary school in Ambattur," says Ramadoss.

The residents federation notes that most of these boys go to GCC's school in Aynampakkam to pursue higher secondary which is around five kilometres from Ambattur or other schools in far away places. "Class 12 is a crucial phase and travelling eats into the students' time. It may be noted frequency of buses to Aynampakkam is also poor. Hence, we request the elected representatives to do the needful," says S. Suresh, president, United Welfare Associations of Ambattur.

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‘Footpath in Koyambedu on PH Road is unfriendly’

NAYANTARA NAMBIAR

Ideally taking the metro train from Koyambedu metro station would mean a short walk on the pavement to the metro station, but this walk is far from pleasant.

This particular pavement on the Poonamallee High Road extending from the Koyambedu metro station, past the CMRL office and towards Nerkundram, exists, but is used for everything except for a way to help pedestrians.

This pavement is being used as a storage space for construction materials, for shops and street vendors selling vegetables, a food shack, a house for homeless people and as an open public convenience. It also functions as an animal toilet for the herd of buffaloes that take a stroll down that stretch.

One can take a risk by walking on the road, with all the vehicles zooming past inches from them. But the worst is in the monsoon season, when the rainwaters flood the road. You



The footpath in Koyambedu on Poonamallee High Road.
PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

are forced to walk through ankle-deep water and get splashed by the vehicles passing through. For a city that encourages pedestrian-friendly spaces, this pavement is a sore spot and provides relief for everyone other than the pedes-

trians themselves. Hoping this would be a top priority to fix before the monsoon starts and help all metro-goers have a safe and pleasant walk to the metro station.

Nayantara Nambiar is a resident of Koyambedu



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‘Chembur’s warning, Kilpauk’s choice: will it take deaths to fix this tree?’

SHARANYA GOPINATH

MURALIDHAR

On bustling Ormes Road in Kilpauk, right outside Satish eye hospital, two hazards sit side by side, unattended: a gaping, uncovered drainage pit with exposed iron rods, and a tree visibly destabilised, roots cut into, and at risk of collapse.

Leaning precariously onto the main road that sees heavy traffic including that of school, college and public buses.

Civic engineers reportedly face a choice: reroute the pipeline around the tree’s roots, or fell it. Weeks on, neither has happened. Meanwhile, monsoon season approaches.

This is not a hypothetical risk. Days ago in Mumbai’s Chembur, an ageing peepal tree, residents say they had flagged as dangerous crashed onto a school bus, killing 11-year-old Vihan Shrivastav. A civic inquiry is now probing whether warnings were ignored. Chennai should not need its own tragedy to act on the same warning signs.

The location makes this worse. This stretch sees daily footfall of elderly patients and the visually-impaired attending eye clinic appointments, people least able to spot or dodge an unmarked pit or a falling branch.

It is also the route neighbourhood children walk to reach nearby schools, squarely at height to be struck by a falling branch or to step straight into an unbarricaded pit. Add monsoon rain, slick pavements, and navigating traffic, a routine walk or ride becomes a genuine risk of injury or death.

What needs to happen now: Close the gaping hole in the pavement immediately; get an urgent arborist assessment of the tree, to fell it safely, don’t let it fall on its own; audit the city for similar root-vs-infrastructure conflicts before the monsoon

Chembur is now asking if its tragedy could have been prevented. Kilpauk still has time to make sure no one here has to ask that question.

Sharanya Gopinath and Muralidhar are residents of Kilpauk



Ormes Road in Kilpauk. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



During the event. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Green meets evergreen on college campus

The silver jubilee reunion of the 2001 batch of Women's Christian College offered an object lesson in sustainability, one that shut the door firmly on single-use plastics, use-and-throw culture and excess in celebration and opened the gates to composting of food waste, responsible consumption and green gifts

KANNAL ACHUTHAN

After the film 96, there is a pervasive trend of organising the silver jubilee reunion on a grand and memorable scale. 'Memorable' usually translates to adding extra layers to the celebration, sometimes making it extended to include a stop at a scenic location beyond the campus, say, a dinner at a resort. Rarely does 'memorable' mean paring the celebration to its bare minimum and make it meaningful, not just to the alumni but the wider world.

When they met for their 25th on their campus in Nungambakkam on July 10, the 2001 batch of Women's Christian College embraced the rarer version of "memorable", having the event guided largely by



two factors, simplicity and ecological sustainability.

Saranya Palanichami, a readily recognised name in sustainability circles, being part of this batch, one expected plastics to be shown the door. But the scale of the zero-waste consciousness she ushered

in was beyond what was imagined.

"We did not have plastic water bottles or cups. Instead, we used steel tumblers for water and juice. No single-use cutlery. No printed invitations," notes Saranya.

Food waste was taken for composting.



Ardhra Ashokan, who travelled from the United States for the reunion, said that it was important for women to be able to reach out among their own network for support when going through this phase of life. "We need each other," she says, adding that the experts on the panel were drawn from the alumnae of WCC. Fitness and lifestyle coach Sheba Devaraj, clinical psychologist Debora Myrtle Anish of Stanley Medical College and Hospital and nutritionist-dietician Grace Gnana Priya discussed the importance of taking care of mind, body and soul. Sheba even did an onstage demo of the "inchworm workout", which requires no equipment and deploys one's own bodyweight for strength training.

Gravitas and light-heartedness went hand in hand. After Susan George and group offered wonderful choral singing, the "madcap moments" started rolling. Going retro, the dancers of the batch performed to 'Mambo No. 5', the chemists in the batch donned lab coats to take a group photo and teachers sportively stepped in for a jive.

Jubilee Daniel and Sobana Laxmi took people down memory lane with their quiz. And when they asked what was the name of the mangy dog that lived on campus in 1999, pat came the answer. Nobody had forgotten Henry, one of the few males on campus.

The alumnae got cloth bags made from fabric scrap from tailors and boutiques. These bits of cloth would have ended up in dumping grounds if not repurposed, she points out. Teachers, some of them now retired, received plants as mementos and winners of a fun quiz received gift vouchers.

Spotlight on SDG 3

It was a "celebration" of Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) all the way. SDG 3, which is about health, was in bold relief, thanks to a panel discussion on navigating perimenopause. It made great sense as the alumnae are in their mid-forties.

Alumni of school in Villivakkam sponsor two students

Recently, the 2000 batch of St. John's Matriculation Higher Secondary School at Baba Nagar in Villivakkam sponsored two current students for the 2026-27 academic year as a mark of gratitude to the institution.

Twenty alumni from the 2000 batch made this happen. According to a communication from the batch, this thought had been with them for a long time.

The communication added that the school principal Sheela had selected two deserving students of the current batch for the sponsorship. One student was orphaned during the pandemic when both parents died. The other student is from a family where a parent is deaf and dumb.

The school had organised a special assembly where the alumni were felicitated.

New menu at Andhra restaurant



Pulusu Ruchulu, a restaurant in Anna Nagar, has renovated its premises. According to a press release, it offers authentic Andhra cuisine.

Further, the restaurant has added new items to its menu. They include: Ragi Kali, Kobbari prawn, squid Pakoda, and Rajahmundry chicken.

The restaurant is at No: 7, First Floor, Second Avenue, A Block, Anna Nagar East. For details, call 9047123456

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Charging needs sharing



While an EV charging point for each parking lot at a gated community is a desirable ideal, practicality calls for shared infrastructure

LIFFY THOMAS

Data engineer Kiruba Joy's search for a reliable EV charging facility in a gated community remains elusive. Three years ago, when the resident association at the 300-unit apartment community in Porur, where Kiruba owns a flat, refused to facilitate a separate connection for him to charge his electric car, he shifted to a rented accommodation in Kolathur.

Now a resident of Paniyur near Uthandi, for the last nine months Kiruba has been visiting various apartment communities in South Chennai to invest in a flat that comes with a separate charging infrastructure for every parking lot. The hunt has been frustrating.

"After the State Government brought a notification in October 2025 that buildings with more than 50 dwelling units should provide fast charging points, I took it up with my association but they refused citing a safety issue," says Kiruba.

At his current home, he has a 20 meter wire running from the second floor of his flat's AC point to the parking area. As there are only six homes and no other tenant with an EV vehicle, Kiruba got consent from the other residents.

A gazette notification dated October 31, 2025 by the Housing and Urban Development Department of Tamil Nadu issued amendments to the Tamil Nadu Combined Development and Building Rules, 2019. It asks residential communities to provide a charging point for electric vehicles at every car and two-wheeler parking space. In buildings where the number of dwelling units exceeds 50, car and two-wheeler parking space earmarked for visitors shall be provided with fast charging points.

Many apartment associations *The Hindu Downtown* spoke note they are physical and technical challenges in getting even a basic common charging infrastructure, let alone a separate charging point for every parking lot. While many apartment associations discourage individuals from connecting their vehicles to their own meter, some allow it at the individual's risk.

Christopher M.P., a resident of a 120-

unit apartment in Thiru-Vi-Ka Nagar, Perambur, has a wire running from the third floor of his flat to the parking area where his electric two-wheeler is parked.

"Currently we have 6 electric vehicles in our community and the association was considering putting up a common charging point, but the vendor came up with the condition that even outsiders should be allowed to use the facility, which was not accepted, so we continue with this arrangement," says Christopher.

Many users like Kiruba who have switched to EV to reduce the budget on their fuel bills feel having just one or two charging points does not serve the purpose.

"For instance, it takes eight hours to charge my car and if there are even half-a-dozen EV cars in the community so you need an ample number of charging points," says Kiruba. He adds, "Charging from my home is cheaper than doing so at a common point as the latter involves a commercial rate and a fee for the vendor and association. So I am now looking for a community that also offers solar so my electricity bill would reduce drastically."

CREDAI's stand

After the State Government notification, the Confederation of Real Estate Developers' Association of India - Chennai sent a letter to the Additional Chief Secretary, Housing and Urban Development Department in November 2025, stating that it is not possible to provide individual charging infrastructure even in their upcoming projects.

"The requirement of a one-to-one charger-to-parking ratio may be technically unnecessary, financially burdensome, and operationally impractical, especially in large residential developments," reads the letter signed by A. Mohamed Ali, president, CREDAI- Chennai.

The Confederation suggested that Tamil Nadu follow a progressive, scalable model that includes a minimum of three EV chargers for buildings with 10-75 parking slots; one charger per 25 parking slots thereafter; upgradation to one per 18 slots by 2030 and one per 15 slots by 2035; and mandatory trunking, ducting and electrical provisioning to double capacity when required.

99 and counting

Enduring gems

Even as Music Academy is on course to complete its hundredth year, three other enterprises, also born on Madras soil in 1927, are headed in the same direction. A salute to auction house Murray & Co, pen seller Gem & Co and timeless rose milk sensation Kalathi Shop for their endurance and uniqueness

LAKSHMY HARIKRISHNAN

There are four parts to longevity in business. One part is ingenuity, and the other three are just plain, old-fashioned, boring stick-to-itiveness. Those four parts working in perfect synchronicity, seller of pens, a whopping number of them fountain pens, Gem & Co has continued at the same address on NSC Bose Road in George Town for no less than 99 years. As it is poised to complete 100 years of existence in February 2027, there are no signs it could be running out of ink.

M. Pratap Kumar, representing the third-generation at the reins of Gem & Co after grandfather M.C. Cunnann and father M. Prabhat Kumar, has had greater need for those three parts because of the times in which he is holding those reins. Pratap is penning Gem & Co's brand story challenging the digital onslaught as seen by the writing pad being increasingly replaced by the keyboard.

And then there are the mundane hiccups, the gremlins that play a nasty trick on you when you do not even suspect their existence. Having seen 64 summers, Pratap has had a share of these niggles, finding some of those summers tough, and some winters too, the latter indicated by the shop's increased height.

"We had to increase the height of the shop because of the water coming in during every rain as a result of the road level going up over the decades, and we had to

pump out the water or manually push it out," explains Pratap.

The overarching challenge however comes from the digital takeover of writing and the pervasive disposable, throwaway culture particularly pronounced where stationery is concerned. In 1927, when his grandfather M.C. Cunnann and business partner S. Venkatarangam Chetty were seeking to shift the focus of their business from general trade to one focussed on an exclusive product line, and the lot fell on fountain pens and Gem & Co as its known today was born, no hazy clouds of doubt hung over the decision. The clouds would not drift in for many decades to follow. Back then selling fountain pens was a sensible choice as children often went through the grades with the same fountain pen.

"Now , this business is not feasible, but we are still running it because of the passion we have for fountain pens. It is running in my blood," Pratap observes, sheer pride in the trade overriding everyday realities. "The profit is less; customers have become less." Pratap has steered the family business since 1985 and the enthusiasm for designing and selling fountain pens, particularly hand-crafted artisanal pens has not flagged. True to what its name is associated with, the Gama line of fountain pens made and marketed by Gem & Co remains "undefeated". It is named after the legendary undefeated pehalwani wrestler Ghulam Hussain Baksh Bhat (1878-1960) who went by the ring name "The Great Gama".

"My grandfather was a patriot and a freedom fighter; he wanted the pen to be named after an Indian hero," Pratap observes. "My grandfather would have thought

the pen would be as strong as the wrestler."

Pratap reveals that "the making of plastic moulded pens are outsourced to manufacturers elsewhere in India such as Mumbai. The ebonite, hand-crafted pens are made by us." Though remaining steadfast to its ebonite craftsmanship, the company has embraced the changing times by introducing models, vibrant acrylic and transparent demonstrator fountain pens among them, likely to appeal to the younger generations. The store also repairs fountain pens, restoring what are treasured possessions to their keepers and cannot be valued in purely materialistic terms.

Who actually keeps Gem & Co up and writing its long story?

Certainly not those like this reporter who was briefly drawn to a fountain pen just to have an experience close to that of a Victorian writer hunched over an unwritten page, a dip pen in hand, a lit candle on the table, and perhaps, a dramatic rumble of thunder disturbing the quiet. The patrons of Gem & Co are not drawn to

fountain pens on account of a fleeting excitement; they have written the use of fountain pens into their everyday script.

"We are able to sustain the business because of the generation that has been buying from us for 40, 50 and 60 years. But the customer base is not restricted to them. A steadfast customer, who is 92

years old, continues to buy from us, now for his grandchildren. People from those generations pass on the interest to their children and grandchildren, who head to our shop to buy fountain pens.

A 'rose' keeps blooming

Kalathi Shop at North Mada Street in Mylapore shuns the glare of public attention. Text requests for newspaper interviews can go unanswered. Considerable ink about Kalathi shop has been spilt on newsprint; and the novelty of press coverage has long worn off. Food bloggers and vloggers have offered it their share of glorification; there are enough bytes about Kalathi out there to sustain a 24-hour nonstop programming schedule on television. On Google, Kalathi shop manages an impressive 4.3 against 4,193 Reviews.

So much attention being showered on a petty shop, its limited dimensions and address unchanged since its inception in 1927, for what? A drink it fills a small rectangular pet bottle with. Its rose milk has captured generations of taste buds. It sells other items including newspapers, but reels in visitors from far and wide for its rose milk, and has consolidated a set of loyal followers far beyond Mylapore's radius.

For the last 15 years since he discovered this shop, Suresh Kumar. V., a resident of Valasaravakkam, has headed to North Mada Street many a time just to savour the chilled drink.

Many try to recreate the taste at home buying rose milk essence from Kalathi. Siji S., a resident of Nungambakkam, says she has experimented with Kalathi's rose milk essence several times. While she has come close, she admits she has never been able to plicate the exact taste.

Pratap seeks to present a proper measure of fountain pens, one shorn of the romance that goes with them. They are "economical, eco-friendly and remarkably durable"; he however, believes their value lies beyond practicality.



Gem & Co at NSC Bose Road in George Town.

'Every transaction is special': Murray & co

Any popular music consumer who scours the decades for earworms would be familiar with the phrase "Hammer time", sung elegantly by M.C. Hammer in his "U Can't Touch This". In Madras and now Chennai, a different form of 'Hammer time' has been playing out since February 10, 1927 when Murray & Co saw the light. In the 99 years plus a few months of its existence, the auction house has not given that hammer a break except for a couple of times due to inescapable situations. What does the continuity mean to those at the helm of Murray & Co?

Hemant Srivatsa, partner, Murray & Co., responds: "We are very proud of it. We have conducted Sunday auctions almost without fail since our inception. There were a few weeks during our relocation when we had to pause, and of course, the pandemic was the longest period we could not hold auctions. Other than that, we have kept the tradition going."

Enterprises can dig their feet in, 'take over' a place by imprinting their character on it. And one cannot think of that place anymore without that enterprise popping up in the mind. And then enterprises take over people's mind space,

Since February 10, 1927, the hammer at this auction house has not had a break except for two seasons. The operational space has changed a few times, but its place in people's mind space has not



The team at Murray & Co

becoming a household name. Murray & Co has done both. After being identified with one space for a long time, a space behind the iconic LIC building on Mount Road, it has had to change addresses,

but its hold on the mind space of the city's residents has been unchanging and firm.

Hemant throws light on the addresses the auction house has had to its name.

"Our original auction room was located behind the LIC Building until 2012. We then briefly operated from Mandaveli before moving to our current premises at Gemini Towers, near the Gemini Flyover."

On how the business has evolved over the years, he observes: "We started with real estate auctions. From there, we expanded into retail auctions of household goods and furniture, followed by industrial auctions. There has always been a transition as the business adapted to changing times."

Hemant continues: "Within the retail space, the categories have changed significantly. We sell far more electronic items today than when I joined the business in 1992. The market has evolved, and so have the items."

Online auctions are becoming increasingly popular. Where does Murray & Co stand in cyberspace?

"Our industrial auctions are already completely online. Our retail auctions have not fully transitioned yet, though our online portal is currently being developed. Even after it is launched, we want to continue our physical auctions because they have a charm of their own that no technology can replace," says Hemant. And when prodded to name one transaction that has been hugely memorable for Murray & Co in the almost 100 years of its existence, Hemant refuses to take that route.

"Every single item is memorable. Every transaction is special, not just for us, but for the person who entrusted it to us and, hopefully, for the person who eventually bought it." Have grands plans been etched to celebrate the centenary when it arrives? "Yes, the plans are still in the works. Over the next few months, we will come up with concrete ideas to celebrate the centenary."

SHARON JESSICA MICHAEL

A statement about mindful choices

Packaging doubles as a brand statement. A clothing label at Karpagam Gardens in Adyar, Tula India has dispensed with the branding part and instead made packaging a statement about mindful choices.

"We will ask customers to bring their own bags. Most of our customers do, and we'll also educate them," says Sushmitha R.K, designer at Tula India.

The approach begins well before a garment reaches the store. Cotton is transported in airtight plastic sacks that are reused year after year, while woven fabric moves between production units in reusable sack bags instead of new packaging. "So the cycle keeps repeating. Instead of buying new plastic covers every time and discarding them, we keep reusing what we already have," she says.

Garments are displayed without individual plastic covers. Customers are encouraged to bring their own bags, but those who forget are offered newspaper bags made by autistic adults using recycled newspapers or reusable cloth bags stitched from leftover organic cotton fabric. "Whatever big pieces of fabric are left after production, we make our cloth bags from them," says Sushmitha, adding that the bags are often pieced together from two or three fabric scraps.

The leftover fabric also serves another purpose. Larger parcels are wrapped in these fabric pieces, while smaller consignments are sent in paper envelopes.

Interestingly, the cloth bags are not sold despite customer demand. "Many people want to buy those bags because they like them. But we tell them the bag is not for sale. There's no purpose in buying another bag just to own it when you already have many bags at home," she says.

The store also uses conversations and posters to encourage customers to rethink disposable packaging.

For more information on Tula's approach to reducing unnecessary packaging, contact 8056163560 / www.tula.org.in

The bag bank

A cardboard box outside the entrance of Kazhani Native Farms in Kottivakkam has become an unlikely solution to a common retail problem. Instead of selling new carry bags, the farm invites customers to drop off extra shopping bags for others to reuse.

For Gokulnath Natesan, founder of Kazhani Native Farms, the idea stemmed from a growing dependence on packaging as the farm expanded its range of products. "As the product range increased, the

Aesthetically designed boxes, glossy wraps and branded bags often shape the way we purchase. But behind the appeal lies a growing question: how much packaging do we really need? From sharing unused bags to refusing unnecessary covers, these businesses in Chennai are finding ways to make packaging lighter, smarter and more responsible

Judge a purchase by its cover



Environment-friendly packaging and containers at Tula and Restore.

usage of packaging materials also increased," he says. "We realised that while we were conscious about sustainability and waste management, in another way we were increasing the usage of plastics."

Walk-in customers are encouraged to bring their own bags and containers, particularly for loose produce. For products such as juices and oils, customers are asked to return the same containers for refills. "We will fill it again and give it to you. Until it is good, you can use it instead of throwing it away," says Gokulnath.

The cardboard box outside the store extends the same idea. Customers leave behind extra carry

bags they no longer need, allowing others who arrive without one to reuse them.

"Instead of charging them, we told them they can take the bag. Similarly, if you have excess bags at home, you do not need to throw them away or keep filling your shelves. Just leave them here," he says. While home deliveries still rely on plastic packaging where alternatives prove impractical, Gokulnath says the reuse initiative has significantly reduced the farm's purchase of new carry bags.

"It has reduced our bag purchasing costs and plastics, and it has become a good habit for people," he says. "As others started dropping off excess covers, they also began

bringing other waste."

The farm now serves as a drop-off point for vegetable and garden waste, dry waste, e-waste and old garments. "The transaction does not end with the purchase," says Gokulnath. "It goes back as a message, creates awareness and builds an eco-friendly environment together."

For more information, contact @kazhani.in / Instagram - [@kazhanifarms](https://www.instagram.com/kazhanifarms)

Take a discount in your own bag

For most shoppers, the bag is an afterthought – a necessity con-

sidered only after the purchase is complete. At Restore on East Coast Road, Kottivakkam, it is the starting point of the shopping experience, where customers are encouraged to carry their own bags and rethink the way they approach packaging. Restore functions as the sister concern of Organic Farmers Market (OFM), an initiative built around connecting farmers directly with consumers. While both operate independently, they share a network of farmers and a common vision of creating a more community-driven approach to consumption.

Customers who walk in with their own bags or containers receive a 2% discount on groceries, a small gesture that encourages a larger change in the way people approach packaging.

According to Karthik R, General Manager, the idea is to make carrying reusable bags a natural part of the shopping routine. "We request customers

to bring their own bags and containers, especially for planned purchases like rice, grains and pulses," he says.

According to Karthik, although the discount is small, customers have responded positively to the initiative. Since nearly 70% of the revenue already goes back to farmers, the organisation cannot offer a larger discount.

However, he says the incentive has helped encourage more customers to adopt the practice. This practice has been part of Restore's approach for years. Plastic packaging has almost completely been eliminated from the store, with brown paper bags provided only when required. For products such as oils, customers are encouraged to bring their own containers, while glass bottles are available for those who need an alternative. But getting people to change a familiar habit has taken time. "In supermarkets, everything is packed and ready. People simply grab products and leave," says Karthik. "Asking customers to bring their own bags is a completely different paradigm."

He says the challenge is not the availability of alternatives, but the mindset around them. "People think minimal packaging is difficult or doesn't suit their lifestyle. But it's actually very easy," he says. "Customers tell us bringing their own containers simply becomes another item on their shopping checklist." There are, of course, practical hurdles. Paper bags can sometimes tear under heavier loads, requiring the store to constantly adapt its packaging methods. Yet, the focus remains unchanged.

For more information, contact @restore.org.in / Instagram - [@restore.org.in](https://www.instagram.com/restore.org.in)





Snapshots of the month-long event .
PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



A fest that celebrated Chennai

Through the month of June, Chennai was not just hot, it was happening with the inaugural edition of the Super Chennai Summer Festival 2026 transforming the city into a playground of music, movies, food, art, heritage and community experiences.

Curated by Super Chennai, the

festival engaged more than 40,000 residents across over 35 events and reached 24 million people worldwide through its digital platforms, says a press release.

The city's calm mornings and breezy evenings became the backdrop for a series of memorable experiences that ranged from beach movie screenings and concerts in

public spaces to food trails, stand-up comedy evenings, photography walks, chef-led dining experiences, community gatherings and youth-led activities.

The festival had partners in Greater Chennai Corporation, Greater Chennai Police, Greater Chennai Traffic Police and Tamil Nadu Tourism Development Corporation.

The Street Jam series, in collaboration with On the Streets of Chennai, took live performances directly to public spaces, turning locations such as Besant Nagar Beach, Anna Nagar Tower Park, Pondy Bazaar, KNK Road and the Buckingham Canal waterfront into impromptu concert venues.

Movie screenings

The Marina screening of Kung Fu Panda became particularly special, marking what is believed to be India's first animation movie screening on a beach. This was followed by the screening of Bigil, celebrating both football and Chennai's passionate movie culture.

Sunset Atti, an engaging music conversation and concert hosted by Office Gaana on the terrace of Isphani Centre on Nungambakkam High Road, was another one-of-a-kind experience.

Experiences such as Chennai UlaaLa, the city's first sing-along heritage tour aboard an MTC bus featuring independent musician Kizhakkuvaasi, gave participants a fresh perspective on familiar landmarks. The Madras by Night Cycle Trail, Public Hall of Madras Trail and the much-loved Chasing Colours & Textures Walks encouraged residents to rediscover Chennai's architecture, neighbourhoods and hidden stories.



Rath yatra in Anna Nagar

International Society for Krishna Consciousness's Jagannath rath yatra will be held in Anna Nagar, T. Nagar, Mugalivakkam and East Coast Road on July 16, 17 and 19. The celebrations will include rath processions, 'Harinam Sankirtan', 'Kirtan', 'Arati', cultural programmes and prasadam distribution.

For details, call R. Subramanian at 98400 76024.

Campaign on sustainable lifestyle

In observance of World Environment Day, Women's Christian College, Nungambakkam, organised an awareness programme on climate change.

According to a press release, the event called "Get Low for Climate" was conducted by the Centre for Environmental Studies.

Students skipped as a group, a physical activity meant to symbolise the collective commitment to reduce carbon emissions and embrace sustainable lifestyle, adds the press release.

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Music and dance at a space for pedestrians



Cultural event at Khader Nawaz Khan Road in Nungambakkam on July 5, 2026. PHOTOS: VELANKANNI RAJ B

Handicraft expo at Egmore Museum campus



The Tamil Nadu Handicrafts Development Corporation Limited (Poompuhar) is having a handicraft exhibition till July 19 at Government Museum campus in Egmore.

Aimed to promote handicraft heritage, the event provides a common platform for artisans from various states to market their products directly to the public, said a release.

From bronze icons to brass traditional lamps, Thanjavur paintings, art plates, papier mache dolls, bamboo crafts, wood carvings, stone sculptures, clay and terracotta products, cane furniture, jute products, fashion jewellery, incense and perfumery, there's a lot to choose from.

Purchasing traditional handcrafted products from artisans will support the livelihoods of artisans and craft communities while preserv-



ing India's rich artistic and cultural heritage, the release added.

The expo was inaugurated on July 7 by P. Mathan Raja, Minister for Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises.

T. N. Venkatesh, Principal Secretary, Government of Tamil Nadu, Handlooms, Handicrafts, Textiles, and Khadi Department, and S. Amirtha Joshi, Managing Director, Tamil Nadu Handicrafts Development Corporation Limited (Poompuhar), participated.

Awareness programme on ill-effects of drug abuse



In observance of the International Day Against Drug Abuse and Illicit Trafficking, Dharmamurthi Rao Bahadur Calavala Cunnan Chetty's Hindu College, Pattabiram, organised an awareness programme on the ill effects of substance abuse.

According to a press release, the event was held under the theme called "Together We Pledge for a Drug-Free Future."

In her address, principal G. Kalvikkarasi advised students to stay away from smoking and alcohol consumption and become responsible citizens. The college director, N. Rajendra Naidu highlighted the devastating impact of drug addiction on individuals, families, and society. He urged the students to play an active role in building a drug-free nation.

On the occasion, the students took a solemn pledge to remain free from drugs and promote a healthy society, adds the press release.

School in Perambur launches programme on storytelling art

The Shri Ram Universal School, Perambur, has introduced a new initiative called Kathaa. According to a press release, the programme aims at holistic learning by inculcating creativity and imagination through the art of storytelling. According to a press release, the programme is meant for students of class one to five. Families of the students also took part in the launch event. A workshop on comic colouring was part of the event. Students who took part in the event received a comic book of Amar Chitra Katha, a renowned publishing house of comics, adds the press release



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